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PAUL RATJIE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

On the night of Feb. 10, El Paso officials and residents scrambled after a cryptic notice from the F.A.A. to close the airspace for 10 days.

Senators Ask If Pick for Fed Is a ‘Puppet’

By COLBY SMITH

Kevin M. Warsh, President Trump’s pick to lead the Federal Reserve, asserted repeatedly at a combative confirmation hearing on Tuesday that he would not cut interest rates simply because President Trump wanted him to, pledging to be “strictly independent” if confirmed for one of the world’s most powerful economic positions.

In sometimes testy exchanges before the Senate Banking Committee, Mr. Warsh, 56, sought to dispel doubts around his credibility, saying Mr. Trump had “never asked me to predetermine, commit, fix, decide on any interest rate decision in any of our discussions, nor would I ever agree to do so.”

He was repeatedly asked if he would function as a “sock puppet” for Mr. Trump, who has demanded lower rates from the Fed and attacked the institution’s top leadership for failing to cut them aggressively enough. Just hours before the hearing, Mr. Trump said in an interview with CNBC that he would be “disappointed” if Mr. Warsh did not reduce borrowing costs once confirmed as Fed chair.

Mr. Warsh, who served as a Fed governor from 2006 to 2011, said he would remain independent. In his opening statement, he said that central bankers must be “strong enough to listen to a diversity of views from all corners, humble enough to be open-minded to new ideas and new economic developments, wise enough to translate imperfect data into meaningful insight and dedicated enough to make judgments faithfully and wisely.”

But as several lawmakers on Tuesday noted, Mr. Trump’s broadsides against the Fed have gone well beyond just verbal arguments. He is in the midst of trying to remove Lisa D. Cook, a governor appointed by the Biden administration, from her position over unsubstantiated allegations of mortgage fraud. The Supreme Court has yet to rule on the case, but so far the justices seem wary about allowing Ms. Cook’s ousting to hold given concerns about the Fed’s independence.

The Justice Department has also initiated a criminal investigation into Mr. Powell and his handling of renovations at the Fed’s headquarters in Washington,

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In the Dark in El Paso After Skies Shut Down

This article is by Kate Kelly, Tawnell D. Hobbs and Reyes Mata III.

EL PASO — Around 9 p.m. on Feb. 10, an air traffic controller at El Paso International Airport saw an alert pop up on the tower’s computer screen. It was from the Federal Aviation Administration.

The controller beckoned the two colleagues who were sitting nearby. Together they stared at the F.A.A. advisory.

In two and a half hours, it said, a huge slice of the airspace they handled would close for “special security reasons.”

For 10 days.

The controllers could hardly process what they were seeing.

Inside a Border City’s Confusion Over an F.A.A. Order

The alert meant that no commercial aircraft could fly in or out of El Paso. Medical rescue helicopters couldn’t, either. Business in the city would be disrupted, vacations ruined, lives potentially lost.

“Pilots who do not adhere” to the closure “may be intercepted, detained and interviewed by law enforcement,” read the advisory.

The United States government could use deadly force against an aircraft if it was determined to

pose an imminent security threat. Starting at 11:30 p.m. any aircraft that flew over El Paso and its surrounding area below a certain height risked being shot down.

The controllers, huddling in a tower a dozen stories above the airport’s three runways, studied a map the F.A.A. had included. It featured a huge red circle encompassing the southern border area where they were standing. An 11-mile diameter roughly from Sunland Park, N.M., to Horizon City, Texas, was now off limits below 18,000 feet. Almost any plane not simply passing far overhead was forbidden.

And the El Paso airport, marked by an airplane avatar, was the bull’s-eye.

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SCIENCE SOURCE/PHOTO RESEARCHERS HISTORY, VIA GETTY IMAGES



KEATS HOUSE, VIA BRIDGEMAN IMAGES

The letters from John Keats to Fanny Brawne are “the literary find of a lifetime,” one professor said.

Tender Are the Notes: 8 Keats Letters Reappear

By TOM MASHBERG

In early July 1819, John Keats sat down to write the first of his nearly 40 impassioned and now celebrated letters to Fanny Brawne, the love of his life.

The letter included one of the most memorable lines from the Romantic poet’s lyrical and often despairing correspondence with Brawne, who would soon become his fiancée.

“I almost wish we were butterflies,” Keats, then 23, wrote, “and

Missives to His Beloved Were Stolen in 1980s

liv’d but three summer days — three such days with you I could fill with more delight than fifty common years could ever contain.”

Two years later, Keats was dead from tuberculosis, and Brawne, who had met the poet in 1818, when she was 19 and they both

lived in London, mourned him deeply, preserving his letters and waiting a dozen years to marry.

Over time, that first letter and seven other handwritten missives to Brawne from Keats were artfully bound in a special leather volume, which was then shelved for decades at the Long Island estate of the Whitney family.

But in the 1980s, according to law enforcement officials, the book was stolen, and its location became a mystery for nearly 40

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Clashing Styles and Goals As Iran and U.S. Face Off

Trump Seeks an Eye-Catching Capitulation, but Tehran Plays the Long Game

By DAVID E. SANGER

WASHINGTON — President Trump views himself as the master of coercive diplomacy, forcing his opponents to capitulate quickly to American demands or face the threat of attack.

But in dealing with Iran over the past six weeks, Mr. Trump has discovered that he is up against a nation that prides itself on resilience and delay. And never has that been more obvious than in recent days, when Mr. Trump has tried jawboning the Iranians by contending that they already surrendered — they “agreed to everything” he insisted on Friday, including turning over their “nuclear dust” — only to discover that patter doesn’t work with Iranian officials, who took to social media to declare he had made it all up.

The two approaches are about to come into direct collision, as the United States and Iran attempt to restart peace negotiations. If the stakes were not sky-high — the prospect of renewed combat in the Middle East, global energy shortages and the very real possibility that the surviving Iranian leaders emerge convinced they need a nuclear weapon more than ever — it would be a classic case study in negotiation styles.

“Trump is impulsive and temperamental; Iran’s leadership is stubborn and tenacious,” said

Robert Malley, who negotiated with the Iranians in the lead-up to the 2015 nuclear deal and again in a failed effort by the Biden administration.

“Trump demands immediate results; Iran’s leadership plays the long game,” Mr. Malley continued. “Trump insists on a flashy, headline-grabbing outcome; Iran’s leadership sweats every detail. Trump believes brute force can compel obedience; Iran’s leadership is prepared to endure enormous pain rather than concede on core interests.”

On Tuesday, Vice President JD Vance’s trip to Islamabad, Pakistan, for a second round of negotiations with Iran was postponed amid an apparent stalemate over conditions for the talks. But Mr. Trump extended the cease-fire with Iran hours before it was set to expire. He said that he was granting a request from Pakistan, which is trying to mediate an end to the war, to hold off any attacks on Iran.

There is a reason the last big negotiation, completed 11 years ago, took the better part of two years,

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EXTENSION President Trump said he will keep the cease-fire, and the blockade, in place. **PAGE A9**

U.S.S. Cole Strike Led the Navy To Bolster Its Warship Defenses

This article is by Nicholas Kulish, John Ismay and Constant Méheut.

The American destroyer off the coast of the Arabian Peninsula was taken unawares by a small fiberglass skiff with two men on board. Before the crew knew what had happened, an explosion tore a hole 40 feet wide in the hull, killing 17 crew members and wounding 39 others.

That was in 2000 and the ship was the U.S.S. Cole, which narrowly avoided sinking after the devastating attack by suicide bombers from a group most Americans had never heard of at the time — Al Qaeda — using a small boat laden with explosives at the Port of Aden in Yemen.

It was a pivotal attack on the United States by Al Qaeda before its 9/11 assault a year later when most Americans were not focused

on terrorism. The lessons the U.S. Navy learned from that episode — in which an inexpensive boat nearly sank a \$789 million destroyer — could help determine how its ships fare a quarter-century later near the Strait of Hormuz in the war with Iran.

Iran has established a chokehold on transit through the critical waterway, threatening to destroy any ship that tries to pass through it without permission.

In response, the U.S. Navy has moved in a flotilla of ships, including about a dozen Arleigh Burke-class destroyers, patrolling the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea south of the strait. The aim is to put pressure on the Iranian economy by blocking oil exports from Iranian ports.

Tehran has issued bellicose warnings since the war started,

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In Store Where A.I. Does All, Glitches and Candles Abound

By HEATHER KNIGHT

SAN FRANCISCO — Something feels off at Andon Market.

The front windows are empty, and the facade lacks signs. Inside, there are two boxes of a knockoff Connect Four game, and four copies of a book about mushrooms. A small bowl holds decks of playing cards, and another holds incense.

And there are candles — so many candles — in all shapes, sizes and smells.

There are no price tags, and the costs, once you ask, seem awfully steep, even for San Francisco.

The peculiarity could be because of who put this all together. Or, more accurately, *what* put this all together: an artificial intelligence agent.

Along Union Street, a stretch known for yoga studios, jewelry stores and sidewalk cafes near the northern waterfront, Andon Market is billed as the world’s first retail boutique run by A.I. — speci-



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How Andon customers interact with the A.I. agent in charge.

cally, an agent named Luna.

The experiment — some might call it a stunt — comes from Andon Labs, which tests whether A.I. agents can run real-world endeavors. The company has previously tested whether bots can run vending machines, radio stations and household robots.

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A Wish List for Apple’s C.E.O.

John Ternus, a company veteran, will take over an extraordinarily profitable giant in need of new ideas. **PAGE B1**

An Opportunity for Trump

The labor secretary’s resignation allows the president to find someone who will focus more on his priorities. **PAGE B1**

INTERNATIONAL A4-13

The Robots Aiding Ukraine

Kyiv is using unmanned ground vehicles armed with bombs, guns or rockets to carry out attacks and keep its soldiers out of harm’s way. **PAGE A12**

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Foreshadowing a Tragedy

The shooter who killed eight children in Louisiana had threatened his wife, the woman who raised him said. **PAGE A15**

Rights Group Faces Accusation

The U.S. charged the Southern Poverty Law Center, known for investigating hate groups, with fraud. **PAGE A15**



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In a Show-Tune Paradise

A song is never far away in Broadway’s “Schnigadoon!” Above, Alex Brightman with McKenzie Kurtz. **PAGE C1**

A Worthy Wake-Up Call

With a new opera, Gregory Spears brings a sense of genre and eras of music to the “Sleeping Beauty” tale. **PAGE C1**

SPORTS B6-10

Seattle’s 5-Year Hockey Struggle

The Kraken, who attract big crowds but have made the playoffs just once, feel an urgency to win as the city bids for an N.B.A. resurrection that would further crowd the sports landscape. **PAGE B6**

On the Field, and on LinkedIn

Fernando Mendoza, projected as the top pick in this week’s N.F.L. draft, is among a growing contingent of players who use the platform for personal and professional networking. **PAGE B7**

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Sharon Waxman **PAGE A22**



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Espresso Maker to Go, Please

La Marzocco’s machines have long been sought-after classics. But used machines are now even more coveted by cafes and collectors. **PAGE D8**

